



MEN IN MALE-DOMINATED ORGANIZATIONS AND THEIR ENCOUNTER WITH WOMEN INTRUDERS

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Abstract — In this article we focus upon the impact of women's entry into a masculine profession like engineering on the making of masculinities in different workplaces. Our empirical basis is a research project on Norwegian male and female graduate engineers and their career development in different work organizations. We find four groups of men in different positions in the organizations and with different reactions to and behaviour towards the women; the cavaliers, the competitors, the comrades and the comets. Using the concept of gendering of organizations we place the different types of men within different types of organizations to understand the alliances that give women good opportunities in some organizations and poor opportunities in others.

Key words: Gendering, organization, masculinities.

INTRODUCTION

In this article we will show how different men react when women graduate engineers enter their male-dominated profession. Engineering is often seen as the archetype of a masculine profession (Cockburn, 1985), and the entrance of women into this profession threatens the male nature of the work and the masculine identity of the graduate engineers. In Norway unlike in many other countries, the engineering profession has been a traditional recruiting ground for business managers (Chivers, 1986). The women graduate engineers therefore also threaten the male hegemony in management by competing with men for managerial careers.

The article is based upon a study of male and female graduate engineers and their career development in different organizations. The results of the study are described in the book *Nye kvinneliv: Kvinner i menns organisasjoner* ("New Life for Women: Women in Men's Organizations", Kvande and Rasmussen, 1990). In this study we found that women graduate engineers wanted professional challenges and opportunities for career development, but that such opportunities varied from one organization to another. In order to analyse these variations we interpreted organizations as gender political systems, which then become the arenas for different masculine and feminine professional identities.

METHOD

In our study three different data-sets were employed. First, case studies were carried out in six large Norwegian companies employing many graduate engineers of whom more than ten had to be women. By including various types of ownership (public and private) and branches of industry

(chemical industry, electronics, oil, construction, research and development) as well as new and old businesses and companies employing different types of graduate engineers, including those with and without affirmative action programmes for women engineers, we sought to cover differences in structural conditions.

In every firm we conducted in-depth interviews with pairs of graduate engineers: one male and one female, who graduated the same year and were employed within the same department. By selecting pairs from the different firms we were able to compare men and women across and within the firms. We also interviewed the managers of the pairs, and key informants about market, organization and personnel policy.

Secondly, we carried out a postal survey of all female members of the Norwegian Engineering Society, asking questions about their work and work experience, career, management, family and housework.

The third and final data set comprised a national survey with structured questions embracing all groups of female academics and concentrating on the themes of work and family. From this data set we selected the responses from women educated at the Technical University.

ORGANIZATIONS AS GENDERED

In our study of male and female graduate engineers and their career development, we had expected to find a sex-segregated labour market for graduate engineers in the firms such that women would be found in "women's jobs" or "women's departments" (Epstein, 1981). We expected that women would generally have fewer career opportunities than men. What we found, however, was that there were greater variations in the opportunities available to the employees between the different firms, than between the men and women in our sample as a whole.

The six companies could be divided into two groups according to the opportunities for career and individual development for women graduate engineers. Two of the companies showed no systematic differences in opportunities for career between men and women engineers. The other four companies showed a traditional pattern of gendered differences in opportunities: the men had systematically better opportunities than their comparable women colleagues.

There are some striking differences in organizational structure between the "equal opportunity" companies and the others. We have isolated characteristics of the two types of organization in order to study them as ideal types. The companies where we find that men have systematically better opportunities than women are characterized by a hierarchical organization structure, and they operate in stable markets. The companies where opportunities do not vary systematically according to gender are characterized by a less hierarchical and more flexible network type of organization, and they operate in turbulent and changing markets. We labelled the two types *static hierarchies* and *dynamic networks* (Kvande and Rasmussen, 1990, 1992).

In trying to understand the different outcomes as regards careers for women engineers in the two types of organization, we decided to view these as systems for organizational politics in the competition for organizational rewards and analysed them as gender-political systems. We are building here on the theories of organizations as political systems, i.e. as arenas for conflicts of power and interests (Baldrige, 1971; Pfeffer, 1981; Mintzberg, 1983; Morgan, 1986).

Modern organizations promote political behaviour because they are systems that simultaneously involve cooperation and competition. The members of the organization must cooperate in order to carry out the tasks of the organization while they are often competing among themselves for limited resources, status and career openings. These conflicting dimensions are

clearly symbolized in the hierarchical organizational map which is at one and the same time a system for cooperation, a rational sharing out of the tasks, and a career ladder to motivate individuals to strive for upward mobility. As there are fewer positions the higher one gets in the hierarchy, there will be progressively more competition. The hierarchy, according to Burns, thus provides the competitive situation which is the basis for conducting organizational politics (Burns, 1961).

Adopting this perspective enables us to see the two types of organization as two different gender political systems. The *static hierarchy* preserves the status quo by homosocial reproduction at the managerial level, and preserves the power of the existing regime by controlling the competition for limited positions. The *dynamic network* uses all the resources of the employees, be they men or women, and provides challenges and opportunities enough for all. It thrives on being open and untraditional, giving scope for new approaches.

The two types of organization are both gendered, but they represent different gender political systems and arenas for different gendering processes (Kvande and Rasmussen, 1990, 1992). Following Joan Acker (1990, 1992) we see gendering as an integrated part of all social processes and structures. Thus the dynamic network with equal opportunities is not gender-neutral or "de-gendered" while the discriminatory static hierarchy is gendered.

According to Acker, gendered processes mean "that advantages and disadvantages, exploitation and control, actions and emotions, meaning and identity are patterned through, and in terms of, distinctions between male and female, masculine and feminine" (Acker, 1990, 146). Gendering reproduces the male dominance in society in the division into male and female areas, and by the ranking of men and the masculine above women and the feminine. Male dominance is thus reproduced through continuous dichotomization and hierarchization (Hirdman, 1988; Haavind, 1992).

Acker (1992) describes gendered organizations in terms of four sets of processes. The first is the production of gender divisions of jobs, hierarchies, power, etc. The second is the creation of symbols, images and forms of consciousness that explain, justify or oppose the gendered divisions. The third consists of the interactions between women and men, women and women, men and men which enact dominance and subordination, and create alliances and exclusions. The fourth process concerns the internal mental work of individuals as they consciously construct their understanding of the organization's gendered structure of work and opportunities and the demands for gender-appropriate behaviour and attitudes (Acker, 1992; Cockburn, 1991). This includes creating the appropriate gendered *personae* or, in our case, gendered *professional identity*.

When women move into a hitherto male-dominated profession and male-dominated organizations, they threaten the existing gender arrangement of male exclusiveness and male dominance. Looked at in this perspective, it is evident that the conflicts, power and interests within the organization are not only about the distribution of career opportunities or rewards among men and women, but also about what it means to be a man or a woman in the profession and how men and women are supposed to act. This is what Acker called the appropriate gendered *personae* or gendered *professional identity* (Acker, 1992).

In the confrontation between men and women there is a continuous production of symbols, meanings and interpretations of reality, and a crucial element here is what it means to be a man or a woman in the organization. The analysis of meaning and identity in the organization and among the organization members is an analysis of the culture of the organization.

If we combine our political perspective with a cultural perspective, we can view organizations as arenas where different groups with different cultures or countercultures struggle to define the

nature of situations and the strategies of the organization. The organizational culture can then be understood as a result of political processes, whereby different groups with different interests compete (van Maanen and Barley, 1985; Frost, 1987; Meek, 1988). If we insert gender into this analysis, we can see that men and women take part in these political processes in which gender identity, like different masculinities and femininities, is an important element (Lindgren, 1985; Morgan and Knights, 1990; Knights and Wilmott, 1991). In a study of the structure of power and influence in hospitals, Lindgren (1992) analyses the way competing femininities among the nurses limit the influence and voice of these nurses in the organization. She compares them with the assistant nurses who stand together and all agree on how to act and what it means to be a woman.

Morgan and Knights (1990) adopt this approach in their analysis of how jobs become gendered. They describe a case in the banking and insurance sector and show how the aggressive masculine sales culture was met with resistance from the bank hierarchy. The bankers represented a masculinity that was very different from the masculinity of the sales representatives. The bankers were paternalistic, steady, responsible and cautious, whereas the sales reps were aggressive and high-performing; they had to have "nerve" and "a bit of cheek" to persuade the public to buy their product. The bankers allied themselves with the female counter staff in order to get rid of the insurance sales reps in the bank, so that the women clerks could take over the selling of life insurance. And they succeeded in this strategy. Morgan and Knights show how discussions about the gender of jobs were conducted as a discussion about the bank's strategy (Morgan and Knights, 1990). In Morgan and Knights' case we see alliances between a dominant group of men and a group of women against another threatening group of men, leading to new opportunities for women (Morgan and Knights, 1990). It seems that the alliances between groups of men and groups of women may be crucial to an understanding of the opportunities for women at work, and in these alliances the gendered work identities, the masculinities and femininities, play an important role.

We will show how, in their encounters with their new women colleagues, the men construct and discuss different kinds of gendered professional identities. Norms of behaviour are implied in these constructions, in particular, assumptions about how women graduate engineers may behave and what they are allowed to do. In the competition for careers and challenges at work, the men use stereotypes of women to eliminate them from the competition and to make themselves visible as relevant and competent. In this process they help to maintain male dominance and the subordination of women. We will show how some men and women are given career opportunities as a result of this construction of gendered professional identities, depending upon the structure and the culture of the organizations.

The men whom the women engineers meet in their organizations, may have more or less opportunity to influence the careers of the women engineers depending upon their position in the company hierarchy. Some are managers and they participate in the decisions about the women's advancement, while others are competing with the women for responsibility and higher positions. Starting from their different positions in the company and their relation to the women engineers, we distinguish four groups of men in the companies; the "cavaliers", the "competitors", the "comrades" and the "comets".

The four groups have different patterns of reaction to women intruders and to policies for increasing the proportion of women in engineering and management. We will examine the nature of these reactions below and the way they influence women's opportunities in organizations.

The cavaliers

The cavaliers are older managers with extensive experience who do not see the women

graduate engineers as competitors. Over time they find that they have women subordinates and women applicants for positions in their departments. We have called them cavaliers in order to underline that they mainly represent the old guard, with their polite, protective and paternalistic attitude towards the women. The cavaliers have a traditional opinion of women's gender roles and many of them have wives who stay at home or who work part-time. The older managers find it difficult to "see" women in a technical profession or in management positions. It is hard for them to relate to women in such professions and positions and they would rather avoid it. They have a need to place women in what to them are recognized female roles. They see themselves as being impartial and say that they take on the best person for the job, but they have little experience of women with higher education as colleagues. They are unsure about such women and are far less familiar with them than they are with other men.

This corresponds with the findings of Sheppard (1992), namely that women managers often describe senior managers as the "old guard" who don't understand women who work. The younger men with working wives are regarded as more sympathetic to women professionals.

The older managers feel that the importance women attach to family and children is a hindrance to their careers. They doubt if certain types of work are suitable for women because it might require physical strength for example, which women do not possess. They admit that they might have found it difficult to accept a woman as their superior. One said: "I have never had a female boss and it feels a little strange to me to imagine myself in that situation. Maybe I belong to the old guard which might find such a thing difficult." Another man said: "If I had lost in competition with a woman because of positive discrimination I would not have liked it. I might have been willing to accept it if the woman was better qualified."

They say that they are a little concerned about extra support for women and about positive discrimination: "Women do not need to be as skilful as men to succeed in our company. We have seen that qualified boys have been held back in terms of wages, but that has never happened to qualified girls," said one manager. "It is positive to have the equal-opportunity programme, but it must be used in such a way that the women are given equal opportunities to compete. They must not be allowed to apply without competition," said another of the managers. The cavaliers thus see equal opportunity programmes as giving women special treatment, in opposition to normal practice which they regard as gender-neutral.

The cavaliers do not feel their positions to be threatened by women graduate engineers entering the organization. But they do feel that the opportunities for men in the organization, and especially their own subordinates and crown princes, are in danger. Thus they are sceptical about positive discrimination and other equal opportunity measures in the company. However, women who have been hired or transferred to departments with traditional cavalier managers, have not always found working for them to be problematic. In practice they find them impartial as well as being open and clear about their scepticism regarding the women. "I know where he stands which is more difficult with the unclear and progressive ones," said one woman. "You have to prove your worth, but if you do your job well, they respect you and you win their approval." Thus women can break through the initial scepticism and be accepted as professionals if they are clever and do good work.

The cavaliers are not primarily an obstruction to women in what they do, but in what they do not do. When women look for feedback, impartial criticism and encouragement, they get little or nothing except perhaps "You have nice handwriting", as many of them told us. The cavaliers are not therefore an active burden to women; rather they are *passive*, refraining from supporting women in the same way as they support men. One of the women had heard several female engineers discuss how their bosses used to take over the presentation of projects to customers or

at meetings. This paternalistic attitude of the "cavaliers" inhibits women from proving themselves and acquiring experience of their own.

When the cavaliers have problems combining women and technology or women and management, the dilemma can be solved in at least two ways. The relationship between the cavaliers and their subordinate women engineers may either be one of invisibility, i.e. the men are blind to these women who do not fit into a technological profession high in the company hierarchy, or it may be characterized as a father-daughter relationship. Because of the age difference, the father-daughter relationship may present the manager with a familiar model. It is a relationship implying protection by the father. The mentor relationship which arises between older influential men and women management recruits can be regarded as such a relationship. Similarly the older manager's relation with younger men could be described as a father-son relationship. The mentor situation will thus be different for people of different gender: a son's traditional role is gradually to take over his father's position; the same is not true of a daughter.

Feedback and recognition are very important in the early stages of a graduate engineer's career. They are part of being accepted and received into the professional fold, and they provide the background for wider opportunities and ambitions. The actions of the cavaliers will therefore give the men a definite advantage over the women in competing for opportunities, responsibility and rewards. If the women want a reaction to what they are doing, they have to ask the cavaliers for it direct. Then they get an answer. Whether they manage this situation well depends on whether they have other support from colleagues, spouses or friends, and whether they are aware of the value of their own performance, despite receiving no praise for it.

The competitors

The second type of men whom women meet in the organizations are the competitors. These men are at the beginning of their advancement in the company, or their careers are just taking off. They are interested in making a move in the very near future — a move up the ladder of a technical or administrative career. They have women as colleagues in the company at the same level and with the same education; and as far as their careers are concerned these women are potential competitors. There are few positions and opportunities to compete for, and they risk being compared to women when they apply for higher positions.

Many of the men in this group have wives who stay at home or who work part-time, which may give them a "competitive edge" in comparison with the female engineers. The great majority of the women engineers are married to men who have full-time jobs, generally also as graduate engineers.

The competitors are not wholly positive to the idea of improving opportunities for women in the engineering profession. The official equal opportunity policies are well known to most of them, and they are all familiar with the legitimate attitudes on the subject. They think first and foremost in terms of formal equality. They feel that women and men today have equal opportunities, and they are very sceptical about positive discrimination and special support for women. "It seems to me to be reverse discrimination, and it scares me", as one of them said. "I don't totally agree with equal opportunity action," said another, "it isn't equal opportunity, but the discrimination of men in the name of equality."

The competitors construct active concepts about women which justify their subordinate status of women as voluntary and natural, and which maintain male superiority. They may note that women can have difficulty in getting ahead, but they believe it to be a myth that women must be much more skilful and clever to do so. Rather, women should learn the right skills and get the right qualifications, then things will surely work out all right. They believe that motherhood,

family and lack of motivation inhibit women's careers. Given such a view, the existing gender roles seem the only logical and natural ones.

The competitors are not negative in their attitude to female subordinates or to being passed over in favour of a woman "if she is better qualified." But "better qualified" obviously means something more than "just as qualified", and the attitude is understandable as it is a question of competition. The men are sceptical about women having a different style of leadership characterized by cooperation and delegation, or about women having special qualities or skills in communication, for example, which could be important to leadership. Instead they tend to believe that women might be unsuitable as managers because they cannot make unpopular decisions, or because many women seem to become more "bossy" than men when they acquire a management position.

The competitors thus give the gender issue a relevance that disfavours the women in the competition for challenging work and management positions. They feel that the equal opportunity policies and the focus on women as managers may threaten their own opportunities, and they therefore argue against the idea that women can contribute any extra positive aspects to the management position. On the contrary, the competitors are very good at bringing up everything that could count against women in management.

The women have found the competitive situations problematic. One of the women in our study can exemplify this. She was offered the position of coordinator in her department, and she took the job. She said: "My colleagues, who I had been competing with, conspired against me until I quit. They were allowed to formulate the requirements for the position on behalf of the group, and the job was then defined as purely secretarial. My reaction was to withdraw and give up the job."

This is an example of unashamed discrimination against a woman engineer. Her colleagues who are competitors for the position, demand and obtain the right to define the content of a position she has been offered. We see here a close connection between gender and technology such that the top technical position that a woman was supposed to fill had to be redefined as a "woman's position", a secretarial job.

Other women have also told us about very difficult working relations, in which male colleagues do not accept equality or the woman engineer's qualifications. It is the competitors, i.e. men poised to "climb the ladder" and facing competition for the limited opportunities from women colleagues, who are regarded by the women as the most problematic in a career context. This group of men pay lip service to the idea of equality, but when it comes to the crunch they argue against women as women when they are competing for the same positions. Common examples of their arguments in our material were that not all positions are well suited to women because the work requires physical strength, a lot of overtime and contact with foreigners who do not accept women in management positions, or that the factory workers would never accept a woman as manager. In such cases it is friends and colleagues who turn against the women, claiming that it is best, for the women themselves and for the enterprise, that they do not take on these special jobs. Among this group of men, paternalism is thus a common weapon for subjugating women.

This accords with Cynthia Cockburn's analysis of how women were excluded from the typographic trade, and how men succeeded in maintaining the strong masculine image of the trade (Cockburn, 1983). When women tried to gain a foothold in printing, the company managers who wanted to take on women workers were boycotted by the typographers. In other words, fairly direct methods were used to keep female competition in check. Cockburn also points out that the men's fight to exclude the women was really about protecting the prevailing masculine gender identity of the trade.

The comrades

The third type of men whom women meet in the companies are the comrades. These are mainly young graduate engineers who are not yet in a state of competition *vis-à-vis* their women colleagues. They have either too little experience to apply for more responsible jobs or no current ambitions to start climbing the ladder. They may find themselves competing with women at a later date, but at the moment they have women colleagues at the same level in the company hierarchy.

The comrades like having female colleagues, and enjoy a working environment in which there are employees of both sexes. One of them had this to say: "It is more colourful if there are women in the group. Women and men have different ways of tackling problems. It is easy to see that there is a positive influence on projects where women and men are both working. The milieu benefits greatly from having both women and men in the workplace. With only men you get a 'stag environment'. When there are employees of both sexes, the behaviour of both men and women is more normal."

Unlike the competitors, the comrades agree with the women engineers that by and large women have less opportunity to pursue a career than men. Many feel that the situation has improved in recent years and that there are beginning to be equal opportunities for women and men. They feel a little threatened by positive discrimination and by the focus on women in the context of their own opportunities in the company in the future. Several of the youngest of the comrades are used to women as graduate engineers from their university days, and some have partners or wives in the profession. They have good relations with the women engineers. They see that the women are skilful and clever engineers, and they see some good women managers around them. They prefer a mixed-gender milieu at the workplace; an all-male environment is too tough, superficial and stereotypical: "But there need not be a majority of women, either". Those who have thought about the issue believe that women do have qualities which are positive in management, especially their ability to care about people and to listen to their colleagues. They are positive to women as colleagues and managers.

The women engineers feel that the comrades treat them as colleagues and not just as members of the female sex. They feel they are treated "equally" and that their gender is not used against them when they work together with the other young engineers. The women and men are both busy learning the job and getting to know the company: they are rookies, subordinates, and see a common interest in obtaining projects from which they can learn something. They want to be allowed to prove themselves, and they want their bosses to give them opportunities and feedback about their work.

For many of the comrades, this period represents a phase in their careers. Later they may find themselves competing with their women colleagues, and they may alter their attitude as their position changes. On the other hand, it may be that these men represent a "new" generation with a more favourable attitude to equity. As Sheppard notes in a study of women manager's perceptions:

"The younger men with working wives who are seen by some managerial women as more sympathetic to women's situation have not yet moved up in the hierarchy, and it remains to be seen how these men will continue to regard claims of gender equity as competition for upper echelon positions increases" (Sheppard, 1992, 159).

The comets

The comets are a small group of graduate engineers who differ from the cavaliers, the competitors and the comrades. They are established managers or specialists, generally fairly

young, who have made a career for themselves and are satisfied with what they have attained. They are secure, both personally and in their work. They see their own further development as depending upon what they do, not on a competitive situation whereby they must rise above their women colleagues. They have shown their competence and know-how in the company and have found a niche of their own; they feel wanted and not threatened by women.

The comets are positive to the idea of more women being taken into the organization and to women managers. In their view, women do not have equal opportunities with men. Women have to prove themselves to be considerably more skilled and cleverer than the men, if they are to succeed. "It shouldn't be like that, but unfortunately that's the way it is. It's hard to break with tradition." They know that there is a considerable amount of important information in the company which is obtained via informal channels to which women do not have access, and "it is not certain that they would get it if they asked." The comets recognize that the women must take steps to attain anything, and that this is not simply a matter of following the traditional rules of the game. One of them said: "The feminists may have a better chance than the traditional women, because they don't take the world as it is, but demand changes in it."

The comets see women's qualities and social skills as important in management, and one of their goals is to see a more even gender distribution. They would consider positive discrimination in order to change the current gender distribution, and they also feel that many men would have liked to have women as managers. Their main concern is that the job is done as well as possible. They see many skilful and clever women around them, and many poor managers who are men. Their attitude to women in the organization is thus undeniably positive. They are interested in women as colleagues because of their professional abilities and their social skills.

In terms of their own careers, the comets do not feel threatened by women as competitors. As with the older managers, the cavaliers, they may approach the problem of equal opportunity measures, equality and women managers from a "position of superiority". Skilful and clever women in the organization are seen not as a threat, but as something positive.

MEN AND ORGANIZATIONS

In our study, we found that women's opportunities for career and self-development varied according to the structure and culture of the organizations in which they worked. In our analysis, we regarded the two types of organization as arenas for different gendering processes. In these processes, different expressions of masculinity and femininity are constructed and discussed. The organizations are thus the context for the construction of masculinities and femininities, and they provide scope for some forms of masculinity rather than others. We will now take a closer look at the two ideal types of organization that we identified in our study, and see how these become arenas for different forms of masculinity.

The static hierarchy can be seen as a traditional patriarchal structure: an organization of men keeping one another in place. The static hierarchy is an organization in which the older men have power over the younger, and the older managers choose which of the younger men are to be allowed to climb the hierarchy ladder and fill the important positions. This disciplines the younger men by allowing them to compete for the available opportunities, and it makes them dependent upon the older men's favour and approval. In principle, women are non-persons in the men's reproduction of the power system in this type of company. It is primarily between the men that the jostling for power takes place; it is the heirs, the sons or the crown princes to whom the spoils are granted, not to the daughters or princesses. The static hierarchy is the arena of the

cavaliers: the older men who, in a paternalistic spirit, protect their female subordinates. It is an organization in which the subordinates must compete for the father's notice and favour, and visibility in their work is therefore important for both women and men. Here we find the competitors who try to influence the standards of good behaviour in the organization in such a way that they themselves receive the few good opportunities available. In the static hierarchy we find fathers with the paternalistic power, and sons who compete for the father's favour and good gifts. The daughters become invisible; there is less room for them in the system.

Dynamic networks comprise organizations in a state of change and without rigid power structures. Who owns the truth or has the right answers is not taken as given in a dynamic network. This allows the young (and dynamic) men and, as we have shown above, some women too, opportunities for developing and projecting themselves by taking on responsibility and important tasks in a way that the static hierarchies does not allow. The dynamic network affords many employees the chance to attain power and influence. It suits men who want to make an impression and are allowed to do so now rather than many years on. In the static hierarchy they are the apprentices of the old gods, while in the network they are able to try their wings without being controlled by father. In the dynamic network, employees do not have to resort to competing and qualifying themselves to impress father. This is the organization for the young men with a positive attitude to women, who do not feel threatened by them. In the dynamic network, everybody's input is needed and the women are visible as professionals. The paternalistic cavaliers and competitors with their subjugation strategies therefore have no place here.

The dynamic network is the organization for young men like the comets, who do not fit into the father's hierarchy, waiting for opportunities. In their rebellion against the traditional organizations of the fathers they form an alliance with the "new" women — the women graduate engineers. In these days of equal opportunity it is appropriate — at least in Scandinavia — to allow space for women, especially women with an attitude to work resembling the men's. Women graduate engineers are typical representatives of the "new" women: women who choose professions and careers like men do, and who do not accept a traditional woman's role in a subordinate position at work. Women engineers want and can accept, challenge in their work.

We have seen that the women engineers had better opportunities in dynamic networks than in static hierarchies. If we look more closely at the women in our study who have made a career for themselves and reached management positions at middle level, we find that most of them belong to a category of women that we have called "the challengers" (Kvande and Rasmussen, 1990, Chapter 11). They are women who have chosen to have both a career and a family and who create a managerial role in their own way — a way that differs from that of their mostly male colleagues. They are women managers. The more detailed analysis in our book also suggests that the challengers are typically their fathers' daughters: they are the daughters of graduate engineers, most of them managers. They have fathers who have motivated and supported them in choosing an untraditional education and profession like engineering. Thus the challengers possess both the technical interest and the class background to enhance their self-confidence and provide them with ballast in pursuing a career in the engineering profession.

In the dynamic networks we see an alliance between the fathers' daughters and the rebellious sons. They find their place in structures deviating from the traditional hierarchy. In the static hierarchy, the fathers, the old men, reign supreme over their obedient sons and daughters who accept that they must wait for their opportunities and rewards.

To talk of opportunities for women graduate engineers in the dynamic organizations does not necessarily say anything about the opportunities for other women in the same type of organization. It may say something about the opportunities for the women who are "more like

men" in their attitude to work, i.e. who want to participate in working life like men, and who do not accept a subordinate position or exhibit traditional female attitudes. The situation may well be different for other women, or for women at lower levels in the organization.

We suggest that when the women graduate engineers have good opportunities in dynamic organizations, it is because they match the dominant male group (the young dynamic men) in the company in their views on work and organization, and in their opposition to the traditional hierarchical rule. The two groups "find" each other in their interest in getting something done, in different ways and by alternative means.

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